

THE WORLD IS A STAGE. THE CITY IS THE SCRIPT.

BERLIN

CHRONICLES

ISSUE #21
WINTER 20XX
€7,50



4 1987 21 002021

INSIDE:

- KAI MORI
- REIKA TENDO
- SORA MINABE
- ASTRID BRANDT

21: THE CROSSING

交差点

VIER
FREMDE.
EINE STADT.
KEINE
ZURÜCK.

新しい
境界

KOTTBUSSERTOR

U Kottbusser Tor

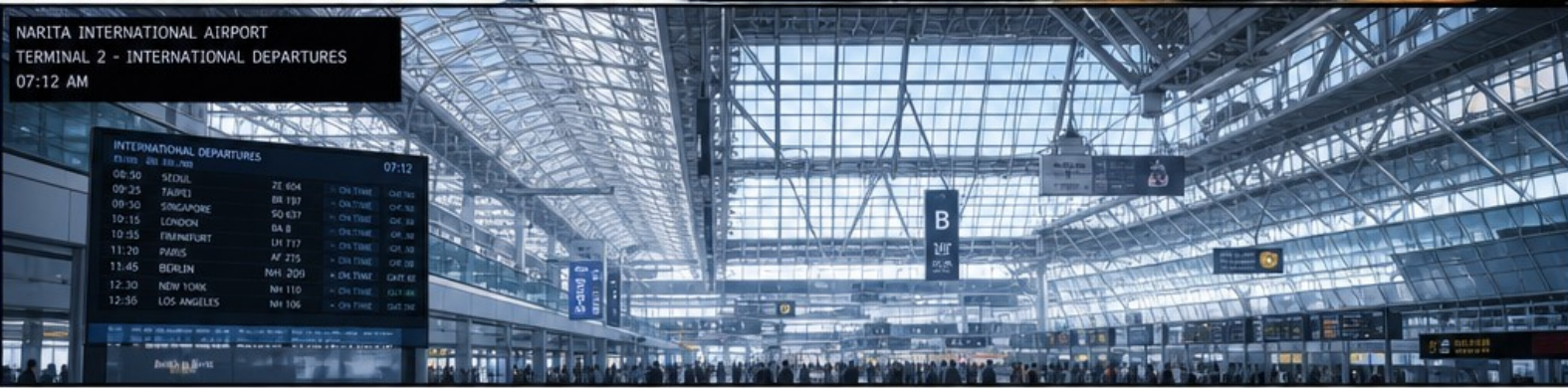
WO KULTUREN
KOLLIDIEREN,
ENTSTEHT
WAHRHEIT.

DÖNER
24H

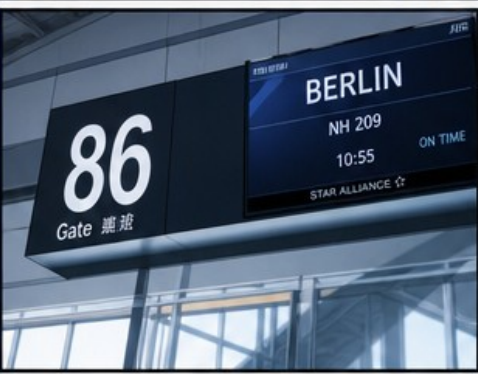
KREUZBERG
52.4976° N, 13.4031° E

DIE GRENZE ZWISCHEN ORDNUNG UND CHAOS
VERLÄUFT MITTEN DURCH DIE STRASSE.
秩序と混沌の境界は、通りの真ん中を走っている。

NARITA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT
TERMINAL 2 - INTERNATIONAL DEPARTURES
07:12 AM



INTERNATIONAL DEPARTURES				07:12
08:50	SEOUL	ZE 604	ON TIME	CHN 783
09:35	TAIPEI	BR 187	ON TIME	CHN 783
09:50	SINGAPORE	SO 637	ON TIME	CHN 783
10:15	LONDON	BA 8	ON TIME	CHN 783
10:35	FRAANKFURT	LH 717	ON TIME	CHN 783
11:20	PARIS	AF 215	ON TIME	CHN 783
11:45	BERLIN	NH 209	ON TIME	CHN 783
12:30	NEW YORK	NH 110	ON TIME	CHN 783
12:50	LOS ANGELES	NH 106	ON TIME	CHN 783



KAI MORI
17

WHY ISN'T
INOUE HANA
COMING?

REIKA
TENDO
18

ASTRID
BRANDT
17

SORA
MINABE
16

INOUE'S GIFT
READS AFTERMATH
AND ABSENCE,
NOT ACTIVE
PRESENT-TENSE
THREAT THE WAY
THE OTHER
THREE'S GIFTS
DO.

AND THE
QUESTION ISN'T
JUST WHAT SHE
CAN ENDURE.

IT'S HOW MUCH
MORE OF MY OWN
FAMILY'S WOUND
I'M WILLING TO
EXPOSE HER TO
BEFORE SHE'S
HAD TIME TO
SIMPLY LIVE WITH
WHAT SHE
ALREADY KNOWS.

THAT IS A TEST
I WILL NOT RUN
ON FOREIGN SOIL
WITH NO NODE
TO STABILISE IT.

NOD.

THE MATH
IS SOUND.

EVEN IF IT
COST HER
TO CARRY
IT ALONE.

PROTECTING
PEOPLE IS
ONE THING.

DECIDING
WHO PAYS
THE PRICE
FOR IT...

SO THAT'S
THE DECISION
WE'RE LIVING
WITH.

...AND
STANDING
BEHIND?

THEN WE
MAKE SURE
SHE GETS TO
LIVE.

EPISODE 17
NIGHT
FLIGHT

ALTITUDE:
30,000 FT

OUTSIDE AIR
TEMPERATURE:
-51.6°C

CABIN HUM:
MANAGEABLE.
ORDINARY.

FLIGHT TIME
07:42:11
(COMPRESSED)



1 KAI MORI, 17

Awake in the dark cabin,
reading the present-truth
of sleeping strangers
around him out of old habit.

Finding nothing but
ordinary travel exhaustion.

2

REIKA TENDO, 18

Asleep against the window,
her gloved hand twitching
faintly.

The cabin's recycled air
and thirty-thousand-foot
remove apparently
the first genuine rest
her gift has allowed her
in weeks.



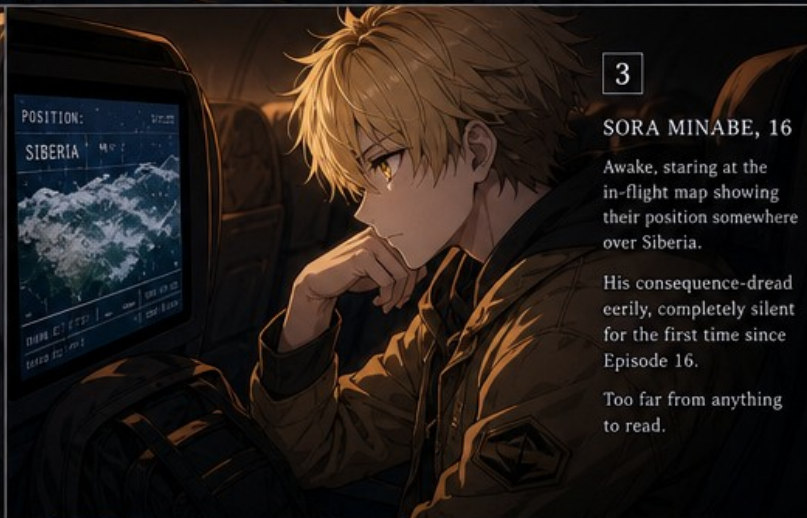
3

SORA MINABE, 16

Awake, staring at the
in-flight map showing
their position somewhere
over Siberia.

His consequence-dread
eerily, completely silent
for the first time since
Episode 16.

Too far from anything
to read.



4

ASTRID BRANDT, 17

Awake, her grandfather's
grey ring-binder open on
her tray table.

Reading the same page
she has read many times.

Her face unreadable in the
cabin's dim emergency
lighting.



FOUR SOLITUDES. ONE SILENCE.
SOME JOURNEYS ARE MEASURED IN HOURS. OTHERS IN WEIGHT.

NIGHT FLIGHT LOG // E17



BERLIN.

HERITAGE REGION:
CENTRAL EUROPE

POPULATION:
3,677,000

HISTORY:
DISPUTED.
SUPPRESSED.
EVERYWHERE.

FINAL DESCENT.

ALTITUDE:
4,200 FEET

LOCAL TIME:
16:17

TEMPERATURE:
2°C

SUBJECTIVE: READER OF THE PAST

NOT A FLOOD.
NOT YET.

SOMETHING ELSE.
SOMETHING
WORSE.

DOZENS.
MAYBE
HUNDREDS.

ALL SMALL.
ALL SUPPRESSED.
ALL OVERLAPPING.

THIS ISN'T A
POOL TO DRAIN.
IT'S A NETWORK
TO UNRAVEL.

EVERY BUILDING
HAS A VOICE.
EVERY STREET
HAS A MEMORY.

THEY AREN'T
SHOUTING.
THEY ARE
WHISPERING.
BEGGING.

I CAN'T
READ IT
ALL.

I CAN'T
CARRY IT
ALL.

BUT IT WILL
EXPECT
ME TO.

THE
HERITAGE
DIDN'T WARN
ME ABOUT
THIS.

THERE ARE
NO RULES
FOR THIS
KIND OF
GIFT.

I WILL HAVE
TO WRITE
THEM.

I AM
EIGHTEEN
YEARS OLD.

AND I AM
ALREADY
TOO LATE.

THE CITY
REMEMBERS
WHAT THE
WORLD
PRETENDS
IT DOESN'T.



TENDO REIKA

READER OF THE PAST
CLASS: THIRD-YEAR

MISSION:
BERLIN INGESTION

STATUS:
APPREHENSIVE

BERLIN. BRANDENBURG AIRPORT.

52.3667° N, 13.5033° E



THE AIR IS
DRY.

THE COLD
IS FLAT.

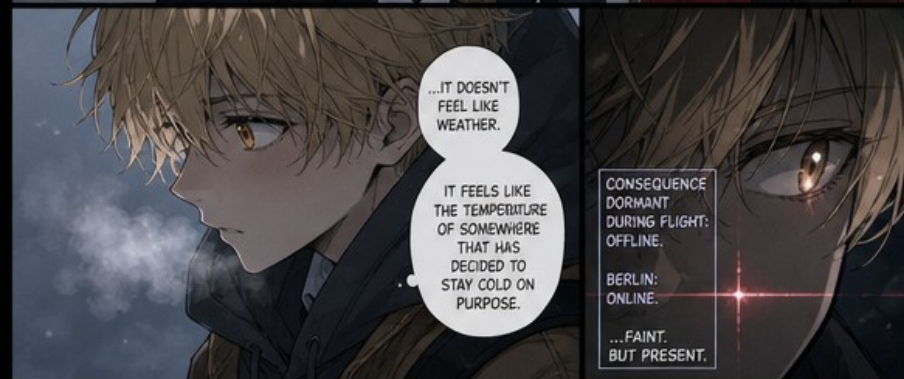
IT DOESN'T
MOVE.



IT GETS INTO
STONE.

AND STAYS
THERE.

THIS ISN'T
WEATHER.
IT'S
ARCHITECTURE.
IT'S
BERLIN.



....IT DOESN'T
FEEL LIKE
WEATHER.

IT FEELS LIKE
THE TEMPERATURE
OF SOMEWHERE
THAT HAS
DECIDED TO
STAY COLD ON
PURPOSE.

CONSEQUENCE
DORMANT
DURING FLIGHT:
OFFLINE.

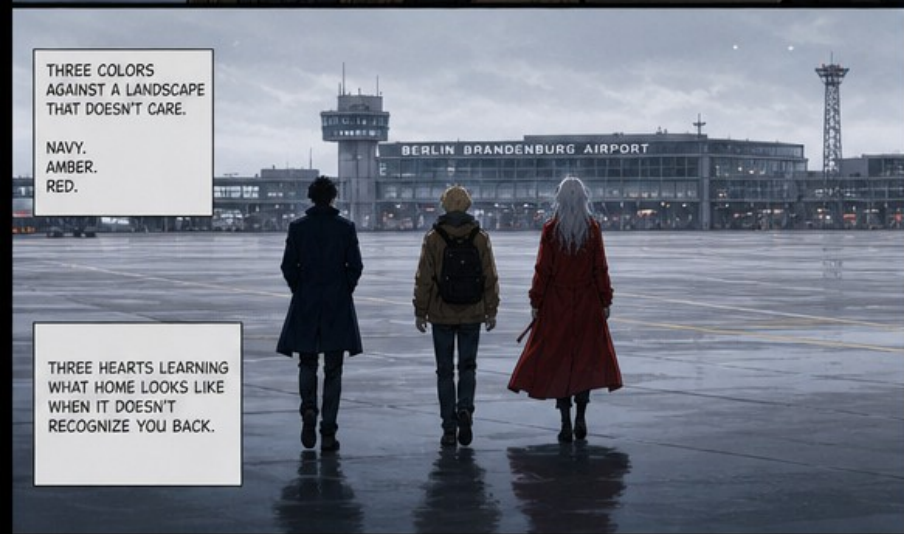
BERLIN:
ONLINE.

...FAINT.
BUT PRESENT.

THREE COLORS
AGAINST A LANDSCAPE
THAT DOESN'T CARE.

NAVY.
AMBER.
RED.

THREE HEARTS LEARNING
WHAT HOME LOOKS LIKE
WHEN IT DOESN'T
RECOGNIZE YOU BACK.



HOME.

NOT A
FEELING.
A FACT.



BERLIN U-BAHN
U1 RICHTUNG
KREUZBERG
18:47

NÄCHSTER HALT
KOTTBUSSE TOR.
UMSTEIGEMÖGLICHKEIT
ZU DEN BUSLINIEN...

ACHTUNG, DIE
TÜREN SCHLIESSEN.
BITTE ZURÜCKBLEIBEN.

KREUZBERG
BLEIBT
BUNT

DEUTSCH.
TÜRKISCH.
ARABISCH.
KURDISCH.

SO VIELE
SPRACHEN.
SO VIELE
WAHRHEITEN.

DIE WAHRHEIT
IST NICHT EINS.

KULTUR.
KONTEXT.
GESCHICHTE.

SCHICHTEN
ÜBER SCHICHTEN.

Kottbusser Tor

DIE WAHRHEIT
ENTZIEHT SICH.

ZUM ERSTEN MAL...
KANN ICH NICHT
ALLES LESEN.

KREUZBERG.

EIN ANDERER
PULS.

EIN ANDERES
BERLIN.

SO VIELE
GESCHICHTEN.

SO VIEL
SCHMERZ.

ABER AUCH...
SO VIEL LEBEN.

ZUHAUSE.

ES GIBT KEINEN
ANDEREN ORT
WIE DIESEN.

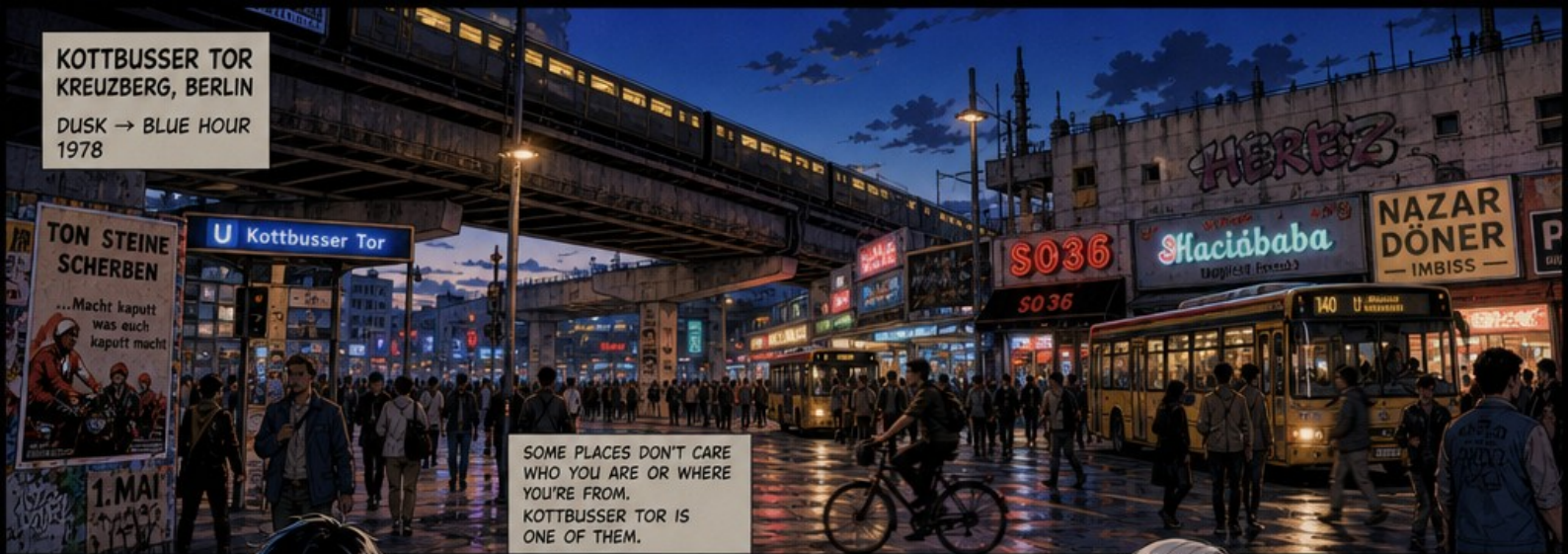
KREUZBERG.
WIR KOMMEN.

Kottbusser Tor

KEIN
MENSCH
IST ILLEGAL

KOTTBUSSE TOR
KREUZBERG, BERLIN

DUSK → BLUE HOUR
1978



SOME PLACES DON'T CARE
WHO YOU ARE OR WHERE
YOU'RE FROM.
KOTTBUSSE TOR IS
ONE OF THEM.



EVERY SIGNAL
IS NOISE.
EVERY FACE,
A LIE.

FILTH,
INEFFICIENCY,
INSTITUTIONAL
DECAY.

SO MANY
STORIES ALL
AT ONCE...
IT HURTS.

HOME.



PATTERN
RECOGNITION
OVERLOAD.

RESOURCES
WASTED.
SYSTEMS
FAILED.
BEHAVIOR
IRRATIONAL.

BEAUTY AND
UGLINESS
SHARING THE
SAME BREATH.

HOW DO YOU
CHOOSE WHAT
TO PROTECT?

THIS CITY
RAISED ME.

IT DOESN'T
NEED TO
MAKE SENSE.



SOME OF US
ARE JUST
PASSING THROUGH.
SOME OF US
ALREADY BELONG.
ASTRID BRANDT
BELONGS.

KOTTBUSSE TOR BERLIN

The silence
didn't empty me.

It filled me up
with everything
I couldn't see.

Here—

Back home,
things bent toward
one truth.

They bend toward
every truth.

Up—
the sky holds
witness.

Under—
what's buried
in the tracks.

There—
what the walls
won't confess.

Away—
what the streets
remember.

Too much.

Yes.

It is like
that here.

You get used
to pointing at
more than one
thing.

JUST OFF
GÖRLITZER PARK.
KREUZBERG.

A PRE-WAR ALTBAU.
THE FACADE NEVER
STOPPED WEARING
ITS PAST.

PATCHES IN THE BRICKWORK.
REPAIRS THAT OUTLASTED
EVERYTHING BUT TIME.

ASTRID BRANDT
UNLOCKS THE STREET DOOR
WITH THE UNTHINKING EASE
OF MUSCLE MEMORY.

A HEAVY DOOR.
A WORN BRASS PANEL.
NAMES LAYERED LIKE
GHOSTS.

EVERY BUZZER
A SMALL, IGNOREABLE
HISTORY.

OLD WOOD POLISH.
SOMEONE ELSE'S DINNER.
AND THE COLD MINERAL
SMELL OF A BUILDING
OLD ENOUGH TO HAVE
ITS OWN CLIMATE.

ASTRID MOVES THROUGH
THE WORN DETAIL
WITH IRONIC COMPOSURE
AND FEARLESS
SELF-POSSESSION.

THE ALTBAU HOLDS
ITS HISTORY CLOSE.
IT HAS NOT YET
DECIDED IF WE
ARE PART OF IT.

KAI MORI
OBSERVES THE
COLD GEOMETRY
AND DECAY.

EVERY ANGLE.
EVERY WEAR PATTERN.
EVERY INEFFICIENCY.

DATA. PATTERN.
PREDICT. ADAPT.

REIKA TENDO
LETS HER GLOVED
HAND TRACE THE
BANISTER.

SMOOTH FROM
A CENTURY OF
HANDS.

SHE DOES NOT READ IT.
NOT YET. SHE CONSERVES
HERSELF FOR WHAT
IS ACTUALLY NECESSARY.

EXHAUSTION IS A LUXURY.
DISCIPLINE IS AN INHERITANCE.

SORA MINABE
FEELS THE WEIGHT
OF THE BUILDING—
AND THE PEOPLE
BESIDE HIM.

WARMTH AS
QUIET ARMOR.

PROTECT. SUPPORT.
WATCH THEIR BACKS.

THE BUILDING'S
COLD CLIMATE
WRAPS AROUND
US ALL.

WE ASCEND
INTO SHADOW.
INTO ARCHITECTURAL
MEMORY.

HIGH CEILINGS.
PRE-WAR BONES.
SINGLE WINDOW
TO THE PARK.

SPARE. FUNCTIONAL.
EVERYTHING IN ITS
PLACE. EVERYTHING
THAT MATTERS.

YOU MUST
BE EXHAUSTED.
MAKE YOURSELVES
AT HOME.

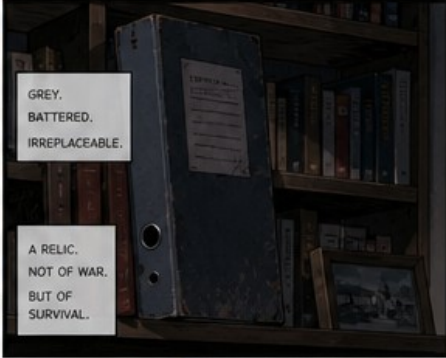
THE FUTON'S
YOURS.
THE MATTRESSES
ARE THEIRS.
I PREPARE.
ALWAYS.

THE RED COAT.
THE BINDER.
THE REST
IS NEGOTIABLE.



CONTROL
THE SPACE.
CONTROL
THE CHAOS.

SAME
ARCHITECTURE.
DIFFERENT
DECOR.



GREY.
BATTERED.
IRREPLACEABLE.

A RELIC.
NOT OF WAR.
BUT OF
SURVIVAL.



INFORMATION
IS A BURDEN.
ORGANIZATION
IS MERCY.



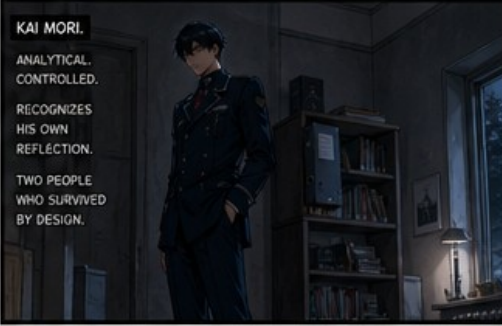
REIKA TENDO.

RIGID.
UNFLINCHING.
BEAUTIFUL
ARMOR.
EXHAUSTION
BEHIND THE
PERFECTION.



SORA MINABE.

OBSERVANT.
EMPATHETIC.
THE GENTLE
CONTRAST.
PROTECTOR
BY NATURE.
ALWAYS.



KAI MORI.

ANALYTICAL.
CONTROLLED.
RECOGNIZES
HIS OWN
REFLECTION.
TWO PEOPLE
WHO SURVIVED
BY DESIGN.



FOUR READERS
OF IMPOSSIBLE
TRUTHS.
ONE ROOM.
TEMPORARY
ALLIANCE.
NECESSARY
SILENCE.

THE PARK
DOESN'T SLEEP.
NEITHER
DO WE.
NOT TONIGHT.

VELETH CUT

ASTRID BRANDT'S APARTMENT.
THAT NIGHT.



KAI MORI — 17.
THE READER OF TRUTH.

JET-LAGGED.
STARING AT AN
UNFAMILIAR CEILING.



HALF-HEARS
SOMETHING.



TEMPERATURE
DROPPING
SHARPLY.



THE HIGH
PRE-WAR CEILING'S
SHADOWS LENGTHEN,
AT AN ANGLE THE
WINDOW'S LIGHT
DOES NOT
ACCOUNT FOR.



THE SIGNATURE. THE METHOD. VELETH.

AND A FRAGMENT OF SOUND.
AT THE VERY EDGE OF HEARING—

"Es ist ..."—
(IT IS ...)

DIES BEFORE
ITS SECOND WORD.

NOT THE SILVER-GRINNING
VAEL-VOICE KAI HAS LEARNED
TO RECOGNISE.

SOMETHING COLDER.
THE CADENCE OF A SENTENCE
BEGINNING IN GERMAN AND
DYING.



THE UNSETTLING
REALISATION—

VELETH DOES NOT
NEED TO BE
UNDERSTOOD
TO BE FELT.

THE LONELINESS-WEAPON
TRANSLATES WITHOUT
TRANSLATION.



HE DOES NOT
WAKE THE OTHERS.

THE FIRST TIME
HE HEARS IT
IN A LANGUAGE
HE DOES NOT KNOW.

THE SAME COLD.
THE SAME END.
HIS SILENT,
SOLITARY FEAR.



GÖRLITZER PARK.

THE FOLLOWING MORNING.



BEFORE THE WAR,
THIS GROUND WAS
A FREIGHT RAILWAY
TERMINUS.

DURING THE CITY'S
DIVISION, IT BECAME
A BORDER-ZONE
WASTELAND.

IT WAS RECLAIMED
AS PARKLAND
ONLY AFTER
REUNIFICATION.

FACTS.
NOT STORIES.

TRAINS CAME HERE
LOADED WITH COAL,
STEEL, MACHINERY.

SUPPLIES FOR
A CITY THAT WAS
ALREADY PREPARING
TO DESTROY ITSELF.

THEN CAME
THE WALL.

TRACKS RUSTED.
BUILDINGS BURNED.
NOBODY CARED
ABOUT THIS SIDE.

EMPTY SPACE
IS USEFUL.

BOTH SIDES USED IT.
NEITHER SIDE
ACKNOWLEDGED IT.

HISTORY DOES
NOT CARE WHO
CLAIMS IT.

IT ONLY CARES
WHAT HAPPENED.

THE SAME GRID
I SAW FROM ABOVE.

DISTRIBUTED
PRESSURE.

NOT THEORY.

WEIGHT.

THE PAST
DOES NOT SLEEP
BENEATH US.

IT HOLDS.

REIKA TENDO
READER OF THE PAST

AFTER 1989,
PEOPLE DECIDED
TO PRETEND
IT HAD ALWAYS
BEEN THEIRS.

THAT IS ALSO
A KIND OF
HISTORY.

GÖRLITZER PARK.
BENEATH THE RAILWAY VIADUCT.

FELIX SCHREIBER.
18.
WAITING WITH THE
PATIENT CERTAINTY
OF SOMEONE WHO
KNEW EXACTLY
WHERE AND WHEN
TO BE.

THIS IS
FELIX.

FOR THE FIRST
TIME IN THE
SERIES, ASTRID
BRANDT'S
COMPOSURE
CRACKS INTO
SOMETHING
REAL.

ALL BLACK.
NO STATEMENT.
NO PERFORMANCE.
JUST PRESENCE.

UNBOTHERED.
DIRECT.

KAI MORI.
ANALYZES.
ASSEES.
CALCULATES.
EVERY VARIABLE.
NOTHING IS
LEFT TO CHANCE.

REIKA TENDO.
OBSERVES.
JUDGES.
MEASURES.
THE AUTHENTIC
AGAINST THE
INSTITUTIONAL.
SEES FLAW.
FINDS TRUTH.

SORA MINABE.
FEELS.
PROTECTS.
ANTICIPATES.
THE FUTURE
WRITTEN IN
SILENCES.
STAYS READY.

FOUR STRANGERS.
FOUR DIFFERENT WORLDS.
ONE MOMENT OF
RECOGNITION.

SOMETHING TRUE
IN A PERSON WHO
CARRIES SECRETS
PLAINLY.

FELIX DOES NOT
MOVE.
HE SIMPLY
RECEIVES THEM.
HIS STEADINESS
ANCHORS THE
CONVERGENCE.
THE MEETING
BEGINS.

GÖRLITZER PARK.
BENEATH THE RAILWAY VIADUCT.

THREE VISITORS FROM JAPAN.
ONE INTRODUCTION.
ASTRID HAS ALREADY
GIVEN IN WORDS.
NOW, IN PERSON.

FELIX MEETS THEM
THE ONLY WAY
THAT MATTERS.
DIRECT.
UNPERFORMED.

FELIX SCHREIBER, 18.

Doesn't carry
what you can read.
Carries what's his.

AI TANAKA.
17.

KAI MORI.
17.

YUKI SATO.
17.

KAI MORI.
THE READER
OF PRESENT TRUTH.

HIS GIFT LAYS
A GRID OVER
THE MOMENT.
LINES SEEK.
PATTERNS
ANSWER.

PRESENT.
TRUTH.

KAI'S POV: PRESENT-TRUTH READ.

THE GRID DEPLOYS.
COLD BLUE LINES
SLIDE.
SEEK.
WAIT.

THERE IS
NOTHING HERE.

NO THREADS.
NO SIGNATURE.
NO REDIRECTION.

NO ENTRY
POINT.

ABSOLUTE
OPACITY.

YOU'RE
TRYING TO
READ ME.
EVERYONE
DOES.
EVENTUALLY.

I DON'T
CARRY
ANYTHING
YOU CAN
SEE.
I JUST
CARRY
WHAT'S MINE.

THE FIRST
TIME HIS
SIGHT
MEETS
SILENCE.

THE FIRST
TIME HE HAS
NOTHING.

NO RANCOR.
NO REDFORMANCE.

ONLY THE
TRUTH OF ONE
WHO CARRIES
WHAT IS HIS.
AND NOTHING
MORE.

THE READER
OF PRESENT TRUTH
CAME TO SEE
EVERYTHING.

TODAY, HE MET
SOMETHING
THAT REFUSES
TO BE SEEN.

UNDER THE VIADUCT.

THE INTRODUCTION
IS COMPLETE.
THE REAL WORK
BEGINS NOW.

PRESENT TRUTH
MEETS WHAT IS
NOT FOR READING.

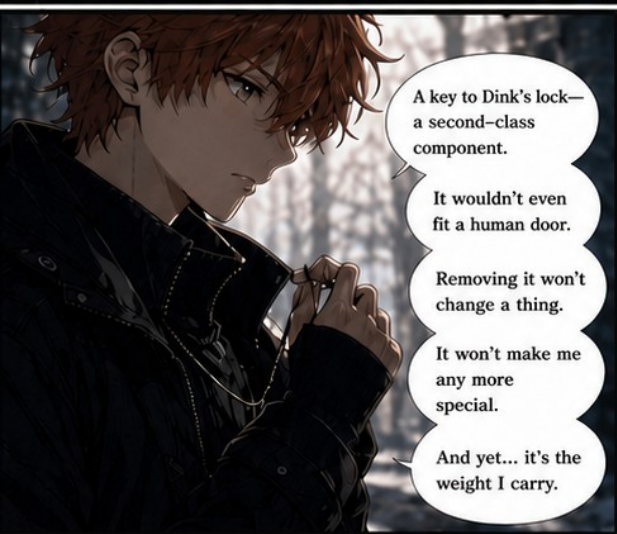
EPISODE 21
THE WEIGHT
OF INHERITANCE

Aboveground,
the sunlight of winter
cut through the earth
with a sharp edge.



What I carry
is not "courage."

It's something
I've inherited.



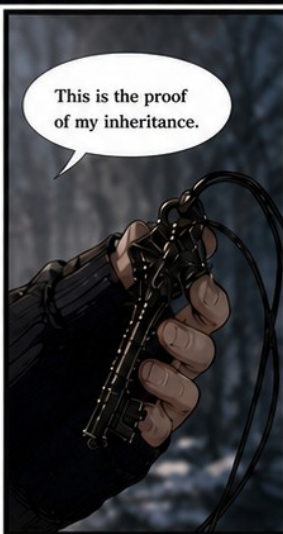
A key to Dink's lock—
a second-class
component.

It wouldn't even
fit a human door.

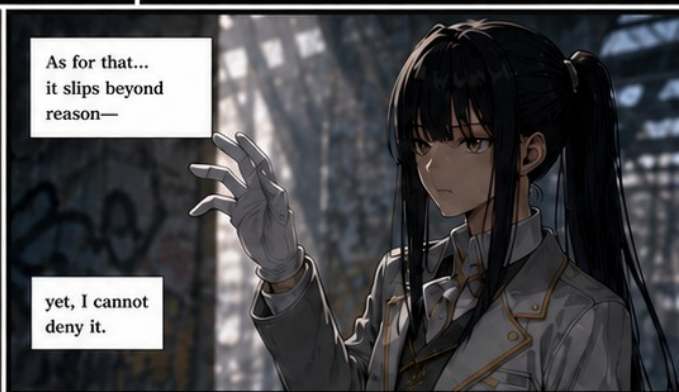
Removing it won't
change a thing.

It won't make me
any more
special.

And yet... it's the
weight I carry.

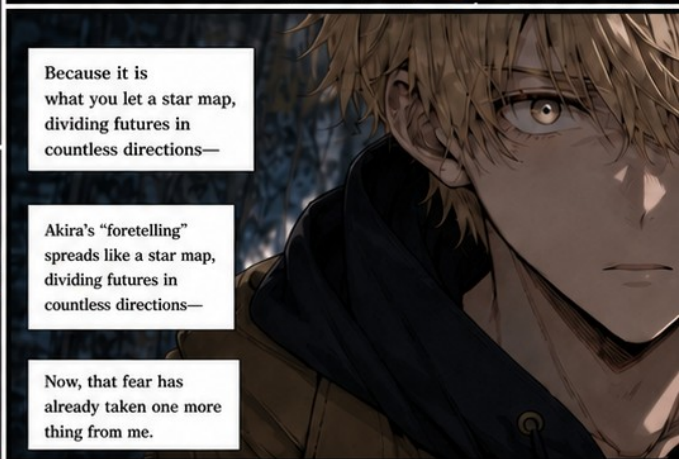


This is the proof
of my inheritance.



As for that...
it slips beyond
reason—

yet, I cannot
deny it.



Because it is
what you let a star map,
dividing futures in
countless directions—

Akira's "foretelling"
spreads like a star map,
dividing futures in
countless directions—

Now, that fear has
already taken one more
thing from me.



Inherited things—
the burden,
the power,
and the future
we must see.